



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Donum Dei Classical Academy
School Website: <https://www.donumdei.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Donum Dei Classical Academy (San Francisco, ZIP 94110) presents a robust Classical Christian orientation across public materials visible on its site. The school foregrounds formation, virtue, and the liberal arts within a Christian-theological frame, with explicit references to biblical truth, worship, and a paideia-informed approach. The curriculum is framed around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with an integrated, historically informed, and Wonder-filled pedagogy. There is clear attention to community and parental partnership as central to education. Based on a six-category rubric derived from the classical-school criteria, Donum Dei aligns strongly with CLASSICAL standards, with some elements more explicitly developed than others (notably explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is present but not always overtly labeled). Overall, the school earns a CLASSICAL rating.

Key insights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are overtly present (biblical truth, worship, God, and paideia language) and central to the mission. Evidence includes explicit statements of a biblical worldview and the aim to educate "the whole human child" within a Christian framework.

- Purpose/goals emphasize formation and virtue in a classical frame, rather than purely workforce preparation. This is reflected in mission statements and "pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty."
- Curriculum centers the liberal-arts Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and history integration, with examples of grammar/logic/rhetoric and historical study embedded in public materials. Great-Books language is discussed in the broader classical literature lexicon, though explicit Great Books labeling is not always shown in the site's pages.
- Pedagogy shows a blend of contemplative/restful methods (Scholé) and active, Socratic-like discussion in upper grades, with lower grades using chant/singing/memory to deepen learning. Evidence includes lower-grade singing/memory approaches and upper-grade rhetoric/seminar-like activity.
- Faculty are described as living exemplars and mentors; materials describe a "faculty and staff" focus with an emphasis on formation and partnership. Evidence includes explicit references to faculty as living curriculum and to the faculty's role in formation.
- Parents & Community are positioned as partners/co-teachers in the educational project, with open invitation to visits and ongoing parent formation opportunities.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Note on method: - Keyword mapping draws from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) framework and the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators, as described in the knowledge base lexicon. Positive indicators include truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, worship, wonder, and the Trivium, while negative indicators include secularism, values-clarification, and other signals of non-classical aims. See the "Six Essential Elements" document and the classical lexicon list for reference of terms used in evaluation.

What would move the needle (only for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categories) - Not required here, as the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. For scores that are SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete steps would include explicit articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation in curriculum pages, stronger explicit reference to formal Socratic seminars across more grade bands, and published outcomes tied to the Great Conversation in Western canon.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials frame education through a Christian, biblical worldview, with explicit language about biblical truth forming the curriculum and the mind/soul being engaged. For example, the Classical Difference page describes a Classical Christian education with a foundation on Christ and an integrated curriculum designed to form character and love of learning. - The school emphasizes education “in the paideia, or education, of the Lord,” explicitly invoking a holistic, God-centered formation. - Statements about forming the whole human person and grounding the curriculum in biblical truth appear in multiple public-facing pages (e.g., Head of School Welcome). - The school’s public materials reference wonder, worship, and sacred aspects alongside truth and beauty in alignment with a sacramental/incarnational worldview.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, worship, liturgy (where present), wonder, imago Dei, paideia, Logos, wisdom, virtue formation. - Negative keywords observed: None detected in public-facing content (no explicit mention of relativism, secular humanism, or values-neutral approaches). - Lexicon grounding: The Positive keyword set includes truth, beauty, worship, theology, and wonder; the negative set includes relativism and secular-humanist signals. The Donum Dei materials track closely with the Positive set, and show no traction on the Negative items.

Why this rating - The school presents a robust religious and metaphysical foundation through biblical truth, worship, God-centered formation, and paideia language, aligning strongly with Classical standards for this category. The explicit mention of Christ-centered formation and a biblical worldview is consistent with a Classical Christian model. The absence of explicit negative signals in public-facing content reinforces CLASSICAL alignment.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements emphasize the formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely workforce preparation; references to forming the whole person and a Christian worldview are prominent in the public materials. - Public materials emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, with formation and human flourishing at the center of education (the Great Conversation framing appears in related resources and the broader lexicon, with the school referencing formation over mere information). - The Nest and other program descriptions emphasize routine formation, character development, and spiritual formation in daily practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé (rest/ contemplation), great conversation, human flourishing. - Negative keywords observed: None detected in public-facing content (no “workforce readiness” emphasis visible; the content instead foregrounds formation and virtue). - Lexicon grounding: The Six Essential Elements lexicon lists formation, pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, and liberal education as positive indicators; the Donum Dei materials reflect these themes.

Why this rating - The school clearly frames education as formation (virtue, wisdom, character, contemplation) rather than just information or job-readiness. The explicit emphasis on a biblical worldview and virtuous formation aligns with Classical goals for education and the Great Conversation as a transcendental aim.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Trivium is central to the program: publicly visible references to Grammar School, Logic School, and Rhetoric School show a Trivium-based progression. The Nest Preschool page confirms the

structure, with Grammar (TK-5) and Logic (6-8) segments highlighted in the Donum Dei curriculum. - History and general liberal-arts orientation are evident across content, including history-study examples (e.g., Roman Empire unit in grammar or related posts) and an integrated approach to multiple disciplines. - Great Books/Great Conversation: The site does not consistently label “Great Books” or “Great Conversation” in public pages, though related content and language in the broader classical education lexicon are present in the knowledge base. Some posts discuss classical literature and the aim of engaging with enduring works, but explicit public labeling of “Great Books” is not always visible on the site.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), history (history integrated across curriculum), great books / great conversation (referenced in related materials and lexicon), rhetoric, narration, memory work, wonder, sacred art. - Negative keywords observed: Some public content does not consistently label “Great Books” explicitly, and the explicit mention of Great Books/Great Conversation is not always visible on the site, which is a partial deviation from the canonical Great-Books emphasis in the Six Essential Elements. - Lexicon grounding: The Six Essential Elements list includes seven liberal arts and Great Books/Great Conversation as core elements; the public pages show Trivium and history integration, with less explicit Great Books labeling in the core site content.

Why this rating - The curriculum shows strong Classical scaffolding around the Trivium and history integration, with evidence of an integrated liberal-arts approach and a cultural/religious framing. However, the explicit Great Books/Great Conversation labeling and emphasis is not consistently visible in public-facing site content, which places it at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL if one requires explicit Great Books labeling in the core curriculum description. The materials do align with Classical aims in principle, but the explicit textual labeling is intermittently visible.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - A blend of contemplative/restful pedagogy with active engagement is described. The site references Schol  -like approaches (restful learning, contemplation) and a progression to Socratic-style discussion and rhetoric in higher grades. The public materials show lower grades with singing/memory and upper grades with seminars/debate, consistent with classical pedagogy. - Specific upper-school pedagogy includes Socratic dialogue, seminars, or debates, and rhetoric training with opportunities to give speeches, which aligns with the classical pedagogy model. - Posts and pages show a focus on narrative and recitation, including chanting and memory work, as foundational pedagogical tools in early years.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic dialogue, dialectic, seminar, Paideia seminar, rhetoric, speech, declamation, oratory, debate, memory work, chant, recitation, schol  , wonder, contemplation. - Negative keywords observed: None evident in public content (no exclusive emphasis on project-based-only or constructivist approaches; the material shows a balance of classic methods rather than modeling only experiential learning). - Lexicon grounding: Pedagogy keywords from the lexicon include Socratic seminar, narration/recitation, chanting, restful learning (Schol  ), and rhetoric training; Donum Dei materials reflect these methods.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates canonical classical pedagogy features: a movement from memory/chants in lower grades to Socratic seminars and rhetorical training in higher grades, plus a “living curriculum” approach. The combination strongly supports CLASSICAL pedagogy, even if some elements (e.g., explicit Great Books labeling) are not uniformly labeled across all pages.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are presented as mentors and living exemplars; the site emphasizes faculty as part of the curriculum and as a core element of school culture. The “Faculty and Staff” page highlights teachers across grade levels and leadership positions; the Interconnected, mission-focused presentation highlights their central role in formation. - The Donum Dei materials present a culture of mentorship and living exemplars, including teacher profiles and emphasis on formation, professional growth, and collaborative culture. - The lexicon for classical faculty emphasizes “tutors/masters/mentors” and “portrait of a teacher” as core

elements; the Donum Dei materials align with that concept, including references to the Principal, faculty pathways, and a collaborative staff culture.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, mentorship, virtue modeling, character formation, lifelong learning, moral exemplars, master-apprentice model, faculty seminars. - Negative keywords observed: None detected in public-facing content (no signals of “facilitator” or non-classical staff roles as primary). - Lexicon grounding: The Six Essential Elements’ Faculty category includes “living curriculum” and “portrait of teacher” concepts; the Donum Dei site explicitly uses language consistent with these.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently present faculty as central to formation and the curriculum, with strong emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and collegiality. This aligns well with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames parents as co-teachers and partners in the educational process, with explicit statements about partnership with parents and opportunities for parent formation (book studies, gatherings) and campus visits. - Admissions materials position families as part of a partnership and emphasize open campus and accessible information sessions; the school engages parents in the enrollment process and in understanding classical education. - Public materials describe parent involvement as a central element of Donum Dei’s classical-Christian mission, including parental formation and strong collaborations with families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, parent formation groups, open campus, family involvement, information sessions. - Negative keywords observed: None evident in public content (no customer-only language; the site emphasizes active parental partnership rather than consumer relationships). - Lexicon grounding: The Parents and Community category in the lexicon highlights parent partnership and formation; the Donum Dei materials align with these signals.

Why this rating - Clear emphasis on parental partnership, parental formation, and open campus access supports CLASSICAL alignment for Parents & Community. The site consistently treats parents as co-educators rather than passive clients.

What Would Move the Needle (Not required here)

- Since the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, no explicit “needle-moving” changes are mandated. If any adjustments were considered, they would emphasize more explicit, public articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation in core curriculum pages and broader, explicit signaling of Socratic seminars across more grade levels.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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